15.5 Measuring progress toward zero trust

As ACME moved toward a zero-trust security architecture, Sam faced a familiar question: How would the company know it was making progress? Zero Trust had long been discussed in broad terms; sometimes as a goal, often as a slogan, but rarely as something that could be assessed in concrete, architectural terms. Sam wanted a method to measure improvement without falling into the trap of vendor-defined maturity ladders or artificial stages.

The solution was to evaluate the quality of authorization decisions. If Zero Trust is defined by assessing each access in context—using identity, device posture, operational signals, and policy—then progress is demonstrated by improving the inputs that inform those decisions and by making sure they are applied consistently. ACME identified several independent dimensions that together showed the health of its zero-trust architecture.

Figure 15.5 depicts these as parallel, non-sequential indicators radiating from the same central goal. No single dimension defines Zero Trust, and none must be “completed” before another begins.